Pivotum

PIVOTUM CAREER VALUE GUIDE · FALL 2026

Is a Finance Degree Worth It in the AI Era?

The planning guide — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, the honest trade-offs, and what to ask before you commit.

8.0

AI EXPOSURE · ENTRY ANALYST / RESEARCH

where 10 is most at risk

For anyone still choosing — read it straight through.

HIGHLIGHTING IS COLOR-CODED

THE FINDING EXPOSURE PROTECTION METHOD & HONESTY

Before you read this

You're weighing a finance degree — or a path into the profession — and you want to know what that choice actually looks like in an AI economy. That's the whole job of this guide.

It's written to you directly, whether *you* are the one choosing or a parent thinking it through alongside them. Where it says "you," a parent can read "them"; it's the same decision from either side.

What this is. A facts document, not a recommendation. It sets out what's known, where the evidence is contested, and where we might be wrong — and then how to choose well given all of it.

If you're the parent, a note on how to use it. Don't lead with the scores. Open a conversation with a risk number and one of two things happens: they shut down, or they get defensive about a choice they're already leaning toward. Read it yourself first, then share it as *information you both react to*, not a verdict you've reached. They're choosing, not you — the job is to widen what's been considered, not to narrow it.

And two things specific to finance. The timing matters more here than in any other guide: investment banking summer analyst applications now open up to eighteen months in advance, which means the decision is effectively made in the first year of university rather than the third. If that route is of any interest, this is a conversation to have before starting, not during. And be careful with the sources — finance is unusually well covered by recruiting firms with a commercial interest in optimism. We've leaned on Bureau of Labor Statistics data where possible and flagged where we're relying on industry commentary instead.

The short answer

Yes for the relationship and judgment tiers — advising people, managing risk, owning decisions. Much less so for the spreadsheet tier, which is both the most automatable work we score in this family and the traditional way in.

Wealth and financial advisory scores **4.6** out of 10. An entry-level analyst role scores **8.0**.

Finance protects the person in the room with the client, and offers very little to the person preparing the materials for that room.

The scores

TRACK	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
Wealth / financial advisory	3.9	4.2	**4.6**	+0.7	Low–Moderate
Risk & compliance	4.5	4.8	**5.3**	+0.8	Moderate
Investment banking (senior)	4.9	5.3	**5.7**	+0.8	Moderate
Corporate finance / FP&A	6.0	6.4	**6.8**	+0.8	Moderate–High
Entry analyst / research	6.4	7.3	**8.0**	+1.6	High

Scores run 1–10, *where* 10 *is most at risk*. For context: *the median profession in this edition sits around* 5.5, CPA *advisory scores* 5.2, *a business analyst* 7.6, *and entry-level software development* 8.1.

Read the table this way: the spread is 3.4 points — one of the widest we measure — and it falls almost exactly along the line of who is personally answerable to a client.

Why finance scores the way it does — the six factors

How much of this job can AI already do?	**6.3**
How hard will it be to land that first job?	**4.0**
Does it have to be done in person, with your hands?	**2.0**
Does someone need a human they can trust and hold responsible?	**9.0**
Does the law require a licensed human?	**8.0**
How often does the job hit genuinely new, high-stakes situations?	**7.5**

EXPOSURE RAISES THE SCORE   PROTECTION LOWERS IT

Here's how an entry-level analyst answers them — the exposed end, and where most graduates start. Knowing *why* the entry role scores 8.0 while advisory holds at 4.6 is what tells you which version of the degree to choose.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

Nearly all of it, and this is the cleanest example in the index of a role built entirely from automatable tasks.

Financial modeling and scenario building. Company and sector research. Earnings analysis and comparables. Pitch book and deck production. Data assembly and cleaning. First-draft memos and commentary.

That list is a substantially complete description of a first-year analyst's job. Not adjacent to it — it *is* it.

What resists: sitting across from someone making the biggest financial decision of their life, judgment on risks that don't match historical patterns, being called when markets fall, and regulatory accountability for advice given.

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

Severe, and compounded by something our framework doesn't measure.

Industry commentary consistently reports hiring as strongest at associate and vice-president level rather than analyst level — firms buying experience rather than building it, the same pattern documented in law and consulting.

And there's a supply problem alongside it. Finance attracts enormous application volumes at the glamorous end while risk, compliance and operations roles struggle to fill. Two entirely different labor markets sharing a degree.

The way through isn't to wait for the analyst rung to widen — the content of it has changed even where the seats remain. It's to enter *beside* it: through the internship that is now the filter rather than one input among several, and through the under-applied lanes — wealth advisory (4.6), risk and compliance (5.3) — that score better and hire more readily than the oversubscribed banking rung everyone aims at. A seat being on offer at the exposed end is not the same as a future there. That's a set of concrete moves, and choosing a program that makes them possible is what the second half of this guide is about.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

None of it. Finance is text and numbers in, judgments out. No physical protection at all.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

At the advisory tier absolutely; at the analyst tier barely at all. The section on the person in the room versus the person preparing for it covers this properly, because it does most of the work in this guide.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

For regulated advice, meaningfully.

Licensing, registration and fiduciary or suitability obligations attach to a named human advisor. Regulatory accountability cannot be delegated to a system, and it moves at the speed of legislation rather than technology.

For an unregulated analyst producing internal materials, none of this applies.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

At the advisory and risk tiers frequently. A client's circumstances are individual, and risk judgments on non-pattern events are exactly where models are weakest. Building a comparables table is the opposite.

The person in the room versus the person preparing for it

Finance is almost entirely screen-based. Nobody in it is protected by physical presence. So one factor does most of the work separating a 4.6 from an 8.0, and it's worth understanding precisely.

Two things sit inside our trust factor. *Trust*: does someone need a specific human they can rely on? *Accountability*: must a human carry responsibility when it goes wrong?

A financial advisor rates 9.0 on both. Clients hand over decisions about retirement, a house, a child's education, an inheritance. When markets fall they want to speak to a person who knows their situation and can be held to the advice they gave. Fiduciary and suitability obligations attach to a licensed human.

An entry-level analyst rates 4.0. They produce work someone else signs off. No client knows their name. Nobody relies on them personally, and no regulatory obligation attaches to them individually. The work is real and the accountability sits above them.

The pattern generalises across this whole index: exposure falls as personal accountability rises. The further a role sits from someone answering for the outcome, the more exposed it is —

which is why the model consistently finds senior work safer than junior work in every profession lacking a physical or licensing moat.

The uncomfortable implication for a finance graduate is that the protection cannot be acquired at the start. It has to be earned, and the roles where you traditionally earned it are the ones being compressed.

One honest caveat about the trend

Finance is the most cyclical profession we score, and that makes its three-year movement harder to read than any other.

Deal activity slumped sharply in 2023–24 and recovered as rates stabilized. Hiring moved with it. So some portion of the +1.6 on the analyst track is almost certainly the deal cycle rather than automation, and we cannot cleanly separate the two.

What persuades us to hold a high score is the content of the surviving roles rather than their count. Major firms have begun testing whether candidates can *direct* AI through modeling and research rather than perform it, including in final-round interviews. When a profession redesigns what a first-year is *for*, the apprenticeship has changed even if headcount recovers.

A graduate can get the analyst seat and still not get the training the seat used to provide.

What we're watching: analyst class sizes through a full deal cycle. If they return to pre-2023 levels *and* the work returns with them, our score is too high and we'll lower it.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Human trust / accountability	Strong at advisory tier	**Most durable**	Clients want a person answerable for their money. Socially and legally rooted.
Regulatory / licensing	Real for regulated advice	**Durable**	Fiduciary and suitability obligations attach to a named human.
Judgment under novelty	Real at risk and advisory tiers	**Eroding slowly**	Non-pattern risk judgment resists; standard analysis does not.
Physical / embodied	**None**	n/a	Finance has never had this.

The honest read. Finance's protections are genuine and both are seniority-dependent. A graduate has neither on day one, and the traditional route to acquiring them is the part under pressure. That's the central fact to choose around: the protection is real, but it's earned — so the right question about any program is how quickly it gets you toward something, or someone, you're answerable to.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Building the model	Directing the model build, then interrogating it
Researching the company	Verifying research that arrived pre-assembled
Producing the deck	Deciding what the deck should argue
Learning the sector by covering it exhaustively	Learning it… some other way
Advising a client	**Unchanged**

The fourth row is the real problem. Analysts learned a sector by building every model in it and being corrected. That was brutal and it was the education. Nobody has replaced it, and the profession is running the experiment on a cohort without a control group. A program that has thought about how students learn the business when the grunt work is automated is worth more than one that hasn't.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Client trust in a crisis** — being the person someone calls when markets fall or their circumstances change. The most durable thing in this guide. 2. **Accountability for advice** — carrying fiduciary responsibility. 3. **Judgment on non-pattern risk** — the event with no historical analog, which is by definition what models miss. 4. **Deciding what question to ask** — the judgment upstream of any analysis. 5. **Verification** — knowing when a generated model or a research summary is confidently wrong.

Notably absent: modeling speed, Excel fluency and volume of research produced. These were the traditional markers of a strong analyst and are the fastest-depreciating.

And underneath all five, two traits the score can't grade: curiosity and adaptability. The specific tools — the modeling suite, the research platform, the risk engine — will turn over many times across a career. The finance professionals who compound are the ones who stay genuinely commercially curious and re-tool fastest, rather than defending the one way of working they trained on. In a field where the entry-level tasks are automating fastest, that flexibility is itself a form of protection — and increasingly it's what firms are hiring *for*: the trajectory toward the advisory relationship and the accountable seat, not the current modeling speed.

Other things to consider about this job

What's genuinely good about it

The destinations are excellent and the pay is real. Investment banking analyst roles start around **$85,000–$100,000**, among the highest graduate starting salaries in any field, and progression is fast for those who stay.

BLS projects **9% growth for financial analysts** — solid, and above the average across all occupations.

What people in finance report as rewarding:

- **Consequence** — the decisions involve real money and real outcomes
- **Pace of learning**, especially in the first few years, which is genuinely steep
- **Intellectual variety** across sectors, companies and situations

- **Optionality** — finance exits into private equity, corporate strategy, industry leadership and entrepreneurship more readily than most careers
- **The advisory relationship**, which people at that end describe in terms much closer to vocation than transaction

And one structural advantage worth naming: the advisory tier is genuinely under-supplied while the glamorous tier is over-subscribed. Everyone applies to investment banking; far fewer apply to wealth management, risk and compliance — which score better and hire more readily.

What's genuinely hard about it

The hours at the banking end are as bad as their reputation, and they are worst during exactly the years many people are forming other parts of their lives.

Geographic concentration is real. Hiring concentrates heavily in a small number of financial centers. That is a life decision as much as a career one.

Competition at entry is extreme, with record application volumes against selective hiring.

And the recruiting timeline is genuinely punishing. Summer analyst applications open up to eighteen months in advance, and full-time offers go primarily to candidates who did the internship. A student who starts thinking about this in year three has, in practical terms, already missed it.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Finance tends to suit people who:

- **Are comfortable with consequence** — being wrong costs money that belongs to someone else
- **Can hold detail and narrative simultaneously** — the numbers and what they mean
- **Are genuinely commercially curious**, not just good at maths
- **Handle pressure without deteriorating**, sustained rather than occasional
- **Can build trust with people older and wealthier than them**, which is the advisory core

It's harder for people who:

- Want **predictable hours** in the first decade
- Need **geographic flexibility**

- Are drawn primarily by **prestige or salary**, who are heavily over-represented among those who leave in years two and three
- Find **sustained high-stakes pressure** corrosive rather than energizing

What else is moving this market

The cycle dominates the short-term picture, which is why the honest caveat about the trend, above, exists.

Where demand is actually growing is not where students are looking. Industry commentary points consistently to restructuring and debt advisory, private capital and secondaries, and risk and compliance driven by regulatory expansion. Meanwhile applications concentrate on the roles that are hardest to get and most exposed at entry.

And an unusual tailwind worth knowing: technology, data-center and digital-infrastructure financing is one of the fastest-growing coverage areas — the AI buildout creating finance work in the same way it created electrical work.

The AI-native advantage — what to actually do about it

The situation: finance was among the earliest adopters, and major firms now explicitly test whether candidates can direct these tools rather than merely use them.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE FINANCE PROFESSIONAL LOOKS LIKE

1. Verify. Knowing when a generated model or research summary is confidently wrong. This requires understanding the business well enough to smell an implausible number, which is exactly what the old modeling years used to build.

2. Direct. Framing an analysis precisely enough to get usable output. Firms are testing this explicitly, which tells you how much they value it.

3. Judge what matters. Deciding which question is worth answering — the layer above the analysis, and the one that doesn't automate.

4. Build trust early. Everything in this guide points at the advisory relationship. Anything that puts a graduate in front of clients sooner moves them up the scale.

5. Understand where models fail. Risk work specifically rewards knowing why a model is wrong about a non-pattern event — which is the entire job in a crisis.

CONCRETE PREPARATION

Before university: understand the recruiting timeline. If investment banking is of any interest, the process starts in first year. This is the single most actionable fact in this guide.

During: get the internship — it is now the primary filter for full-time offers, not one input among several. Take genuinely quantitative modules. Build the habit of interrogating numbers rather than producing them.

Choosing a destination: consider wealth advisory, risk and compliance seriously. They score better, they hire more readily, and almost nobody your age is applying to them.

The routes in

ROUTE	NOTES
Finance or economics degree → analyst program	The standard route. Internship-driven, and the timeline starts early.
Any degree + strong quantitative evidence	More common than students assume, particularly in risk and quantitative roles.
Wealth management / advisory training	Less competitive entry, better score, chronically under-applied to.
Risk and compliance	Growing with regulatory expansion, and struggling to fill.
Accounting → finance	A well-worn path, and the CPA travels well.

Where a finance degree can take you later

Genuinely broad: investment banking and capital markets, private equity and asset management, wealth and financial advisory, risk and compliance, corporate finance and treasury, fintech, and industry leadership including CFO tracks.

The pattern in this index holds exactly. Roles where a named human is answerable to a client or a regulator score better. Roles that produce analysis for someone else to act on score worse. That is the whole map, and it applies at every level of seniority.

What to look for in a finance program

1. Internship placement rate — and which employers. Given that full-time offers flow primarily from internships, this is the number that matters most.

2. Recruiting support that starts in first year. Programs that begin careers support in year two are already late for banking.

3. Genuine quantitative depth. Statistics, econometrics, financial modeling taught as reasoning rather than as software training.

4. Breadth beyond banking. Does the program place into wealth management, risk and compliance, or only into the oversubscribed end?

5. First-destination job titles, not employment rates.

Questions to ask a finance program

On placement:

- What proportion of students secure a relevant internship, and with whom?
- What's the internship-to-full-time conversion rate?
- When does careers support begin — which year, which term?

On outcomes:

- What job titles did last year's graduates hold at six months?
- What proportion went into banking, versus advisory, risk or corporate finance?
- How has that mix shifted in three years?

On the curriculum:

- How much is genuinely quantitative, and is it compulsory?
- How does the program teach students to work with AI analysis tools — and to check them?

Red flags: outcomes quoted as employment rate; careers support starting in year two or later; placement into a narrow set of employers only; a curriculum unchanged since 2022.

The career-hunting checklist

Choosing well is step one. This is what turns a good choice into a good outcome once you're in — worth reading *now*, because the best time to pick a program is knowing exactly what you'll need to do with it. The first list is for the degree years; the second is for the job hunt that follows.

During the degree — build toward the accountable seat

- **Treat the destination as the product, not the degree.** The protection in finance lives at the tiers where a named human is answerable — wealth advisory (4.6), risk and compliance (5.3) — not in the entry-analyst rung that scores 8.0. Aim every choice at being answerable to a client or a regulator.
- **Understand the recruiting timeline before it runs out.** Investment banking summer analyst applications open up to eighteen months in advance; if banking is of any interest, the process starts in first year, not third. Missing it is missing it.
- **Treat the internship as non-negotiable.** It is now the primary filter for full-time offers, not one input among several, and the single strongest signal a graduate can carry.
- **Take the quantitative modules seriously.** Statistics, econometrics and modeling as reasoning — that's the judgment layer verification depends on, not software training you can pick up later.
- **Point at the under-applied lanes on purpose.** Wealth advisory, risk and compliance score better and hire more readily, and almost nobody your age is applying to them. Everyone chases banking; that's the crowded, exposed door.
- **Get fluent with AI as a worker, not a shortcut.** Learn to direct a model build and catch it when it's confidently wrong — firms now test for exactly this, including in final rounds.
- **Feed curiosity and adaptability on purpose.** The modeling suite and the research platform will turn over repeatedly; the person who stays commercially curious and re-tools fastest compounds.
- **Keep the frame wide.** Properly vet the alternatives — advisory versus banking, risk, and accounting, where licensed CPA advisory scores 5.2 — before committing to the oversubscribed end.

During the job hunt — aim for the room, don't just apply

- **Target the protected lanes on purpose.** Wealth advisory (4.6), risk and compliance (5.3), a path toward the accountable seat — not "analyst, open to anything," which points straight at the 8.0.

- **Read the title, not just the offer.** Entry analyst and research roles are the automating layer (8.0), and corporate finance / FP&A (6.8) sits close behind. If you take one, take it as a deliberate stepping-stone toward a client-facing or accountable seat, not as the plan.
- **Don't grab a role just because it's on offer in an exposed lane.** A role being available doesn't make it safe. A firm still running a large analyst intake may simply be behind the curve — and that's exactly the rung whose training has changed even where the seats remain. Availability can be a lagging indicator, not a green light.
- **Prefer the seat closest to a client or a regulator.** Advisory over analysis, a role where someone is answerable over one that produces materials for someone else to sign — proximity to accountability is proximity to the protection.
- **Ask the employer where AI is heading in the role.** Whether they're building the job around directing and verifying these tools, or waiting to be forced to, tells you if the seat grows or is quietly being hollowed out.
- **Weigh trajectory over starting salary.** The banking end pays $85,000–$100,000 at entry and is the most exposed tier at once — a lower-paid seat that puts you closer to a client and builds AI fluency can age far better.

Go deeper — further reading

- **Financial Analysts — Occupational Outlook Handbook** — *US Bureau of Labor Statistics*. The primary source for growth projections and wage distributions, free and updated regularly. Read this before any recruiting-firm forecast.

- **Investment Banking USA Hiring Outlook 2026** — *Selby Jennings*. Useful for where demand is actually concentrated — restructuring, private capital, secondaries, technology and infrastructure — and for the observation that hiring is strongest at associate and VP level. Note this is a recruiting firm; read it for the directional picture rather than as neutral analysis.

- **Are too many students choosing finance?** — on the split between oversubscribed glamorous roles and under-filled ones. The most useful corrective to how students actually apply.

The counterargument — read this one:

> The strongest case against our 8.0 is that we are scoring a **cycle** and calling it a **structure**.

Deal activity collapsed in 2023–24 and analyst hiring collapsed with it. Both have since recovered, and industry commentary now describes banks as understaffed against rebounding transaction volume. On this reading, the entry-level compression we're measuring is the ordinary bottom of a cycle that has already turned, and attributing it to AI mistakes timing for causation.

Where we land: we take this seriously enough to have written it into the honest caveat about the trend rather than leaving it here, and it is the single largest source of uncertainty in this guide. What holds our score is that the *content* of the first-year role has changed even where the headcount recovers — when firms interview for the ability to direct AI through modeling rather than to build models, the apprenticeship has been redesigned regardless of how many seats exist.

But if analyst classes return to pre-2023 size and the work returns with them, we are wrong and we will lower the score. That is a specific, falsifiable claim and we'll report it either way.

Bottom line

Finance's protected end is genuinely protected, and it is not where students are looking.

Wealth advisory at 4.6 and risk at 5.3 are shielded by the two things that hold up across this whole index: a named human answerable to a client, and regulatory obligation attached to a person. Neither is going anywhere.

The entry tier is the problem, and it is severe — 8.0, with a job description that reads like a list of automated tasks. Hiring has shifted toward experience, and the training the analyst years used to provide has changed even where the seats remain.

And the practical advice is unusually concrete for this guide. Understand the recruiting timeline, because it starts eighteen months ahead of the job and the internship is now the filter rather than one input among several. A student interested in this needs to know that in their first year, not their third.

So: aim at advisory, risk or compliance rather than assuming banking, take the quantitative modules seriously because verification depends on them, get the internship, and move toward being answerable to someone as early as you can.

And one honest thing worth saying. The advisory end of finance — sitting with someone making the most consequential financial decision of their life and being the person they trust —

is work people describe in terms very close to vocation. It scores 4.6, it hires readily, and almost nobody applies to it. That combination is rare.

Questions worth sitting with

Whether you're the one choosing or a parent thinking it through together, these are the conversations that lead to a better decision. Read "you" as whoever the choice is about.

About the work itself

1. What made finance appealing? Push past "I'm good with numbers" or "it pays well" to something specific. 2. **Banking, or advisory?** They're genuinely different careers with different hours, different clients and a 3.4-point gap in exposure. 3. What does a Tuesday look like in the job you're imagining? What about a Tuesday at 11pm? 4. Are you drawn to the money, the problem-solving, or the relationships? Those lead different places.

Reacting to the findings

5. Wealth advisory scores 4.6 and entry analyst 8.0. Does that change where you'd aim? 6. This guide says the entry-analyst job description reads like a list of automated tasks. Does that land? 7. Everyone applies to banking; far fewer apply to advisory and risk, which score better. What do you make of that?

The harder conversation

8. **The timeline.** Summer analyst applications open up to eighteen months ahead. Do you understand that the decision effectively happens in first year? 9. The hours at the banking end, through your twenties. Have you pictured that concretely? 10. Hiring concentrates in a few financial centers. Is relocating appealing or a problem?

Testing it against reality

11. **The most valuable single action:** find someone two to three years into finance and ask what they actually did in year one, and whether that work still exists. 12. Have you spoken to anyone in wealth advisory or risk, as opposed to banking? The picture is very different.

Widening the frame

13. Have you compared this properly against accounting? Licensed CPA advisory scores 5.2 against entry finance at 8.0 — worse pay, better protection, and a license. 14. If finance weren't available, what would you choose? 15. Do you want *finance*, or what finance is made of — consequence, money, problem-solving, status? Those point in genuinely different directions.

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation. For finance specifically, we've flagged that this is the most cyclical profession we score, that some of the measured movement is likely the deal cycle rather than automation, and that we cannot cleanly separate the two.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospectively calculated using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.

Technical scoring appendix — Finance

Pivotum Degree Risk Index — Fall 2026 Edition

This appendix is the audit trail. It sets out the formula, the rating anchors, every factor rating behind every track score in this profile, the backcast arithmetic, a sensitivity analysis, and the specific things that would change our mind.

We publish it because a score nobody can check is an opinion with a decimal point.

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1. The formula

```
Risk = 0.35 × Automatability
     + 0.15 × EntryErosion
     + 0.15 × (10 − Physical)
     + 0.15 × (10 − Trust)
     + 0.10 × (10 − Regulatory)
     + 0.10 × (10 − Judgment)
```

Two exposure factors carry 50% of the weight; three protection factors carry 40%; judgment under novelty carries the remaining 10% and sits on the protection side. The deliberate consequence is that protection can outweigh exposure — which is why a highly automatable job like teaching still scores low.

Bands. Very low below 3.0 · Low 3.0–4.4 · Moderate 4.5–5.4 · Moderate–High 5.5–6.9 · High 7.0 and above.

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2. Rating anchors

HOW THE 0–10 RAW RATINGS ARE ANCHORED

Every factor is rated on its own 0–10 scale before weighting. The anchors are identical across all twenty-eight careers, which is what makes the scores comparable.

Task automatability (A) — *what share of the working week could a capable current system already do to an acceptable standard?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Almost nothing. The work is physical, relational or wholly novel.
3–4	Administrative surround only — notes, scheduling, correspondence.
5–6	A meaningful minority of the week, mostly documentation and lookup.
7–8	A large share, including tasks central to the junior version of the role.
9–10	Most of the described duties, at or near professional standard.

Entry-path erosion (E) — *how much has the traditional route into this work narrowed?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Protected by statute or physical necessity. Training hours cannot be automated.
3–4	Stable. Some junior tasks absorbed; the apprenticeship survives.
5–6	Visible narrowing. Employers prefer experience; junior intake reduced.
7–8	Substantial. The work juniors learned on has largely gone.
9–10	The training layer and the automatable layer were the same layer.

Physical / embodied (P) — *must this be done in person, with a body, in an unpredictable setting?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Fully screen-based. Location-independent.
3–4	Occasional presence; the core work is not physical.
5–6	Regular physical presence, in largely controlled conditions.
7–8	Substantially physical, with some variability of setting.
9–10	Irreducibly physical, in conditions that differ every time.

Human trust / accountability (T) — *does someone need a specific human they can rely on, and must a human answer when it goes wrong?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Output is anonymous and reviewed by others.
3–4	Work is signed off by someone else. No personal reliance.
5–6	Some client relationship; accountability is institutional.
7–8	Named responsibility, with commercial or professional consequence.
9–10	The relationship is the service, and liability attaches personally.

Regulatory / licensing (R) — *does the law reserve this act to a qualified human*?

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	No license exists and none is proposed.
3–4	Certification is customary but not reserved.
5–6	Partial reservation, varying by jurisdiction or task.
7–8	Licensed practice, with some unreserved adjacent work.
9–10	Comprehensive statutory reservation, including of the training route.

Judgment under novelty (J) — *how often does the work present something with no matching precedent*, *where being wrong is costly*?

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Routine by design. Deviation is an error, not a case.
3–4	Occasional exceptions, handled by escalation.
5–6	Regular non-standard cases within a known range.
7–8	Frequent genuine novelty with material consequences.
9–10	Novelty is constant, and in some fields adversarially generated.

3. Factor ratings by track

Ratings are the Fall 2026 edition unless a range is shown. **P, T, R and J are held constant across editions** — those protections are structural and do not move on a three-year horizon. All measured movement is in A and E.

WEALTH / FINANCIAL ADVISORY — 4.6 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.4	5.0	**6.0**	2.1
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.0	3.4	**3.8**	0.57
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	**1.5**	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	9.0	9.0	**9.0**	0.15
Regulatory / licensing	10%	7.5	7.5	**7.5**	0.25
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.5	7.5	**7.5**	0.25
				Total	**4.59 → 4.6**

RISK & COMPLIANCE — 5.3 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.7	5.4	**6.6**	2.31
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.5	3.9	**4.4**	0.66
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	**1.0**	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	7.5	7.5	**7.5**	0.38
Regulatory / licensing	10%	6.5	6.5	**6.5**	0.35
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.5	7.5	**7.5**	0.25
				Total	**5.29 → 5.3**

INVESTMENT BANKING (SENIOR) — 5.7 (MODERATE–HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.0	6.0	**7.0**	2.45
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.8	4.2	**4.6**	0.69
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	**1.0**	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	7.5	7.5	**7.5**	0.38
Regulatory / licensing	10%	4.0	4.0	**4.0**	0.6
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.5	7.5	**7.5**	0.25
				Total	**5.71 → 5.7**

CORPORATE FINANCE / FP&A — 6.8 (MODERATE–HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.4	7.3	**8.2**	2.87
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.8	5.3	**5.8**	0.87
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	**1.0**	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	6.0	6.0	**6.0**	0.6
Regulatory / licensing	10%	3.0	3.0	**3.0**	0.7
Judgment under novelty	10%	6.0	6.0	**6.0**	0.4
				Total	**6.79 → 6.8**

ENTRY ANALYST / RESEARCH — 8.0 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.7	7.8	**9.4**	3.29
Entry-path erosion	15%	6.0	7.2	**8.0**	1.2
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	**1.0**	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	4.0	4.0	**4.0**	0.9
Regulatory / licensing	10%	3.0	3.0	**3.0**	0.7
Judgment under novelty	10%	4.5	4.5	**4.5**	0.55
				Total	**7.99 → 8.0**

4. Backcast arithmetic

Worked example for the headline track, showing exactly how the three-year movement is composed.

Wealth / financial advisory

EDITION	A	E	PROTECTION DEFICIT (FIXED)	SCORE
2023	4.4	3.0	1.92	**3.9**
2025	5.0	3.4	1.92	**4.2**
Fall 2026	6.0	3.8	1.92	**4.6**

Movement decomposition: automatability contributed **+0.56** and entry-path erosion **+0.12**, for a total of **+0.7** points over three years.

The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology, not archived scores from published editions. They are our best assessment of what each factor would have rated at the time, given what was then demonstrable. They are not measurements.

5. Sensitivity

How far the score moves if a single factor is rated one point differently:

FACTOR	±1 POINT MOVES THE SCORE BY
Task automatability	±0.35
Entry-path erosion	±0.15
Physical / embodied	±0.15
Human trust / accountability	±0.15
Regulatory / licensing	±0.10
Judgment under novelty	±0.10

What this means in practice. A one-point disagreement about automatability moves a score by 0.35 — enough to shift a track between bands at the margins. A one-point disagreement about licensing moves it by 0.10, which almost never changes a band.

So if you disagree with one of our numbers, the automatability rating is where the disagreement matters most, and it is the rating we would most want challenged.

6. Stated limitations

We measure capability, not deployment. Scores reflect exposure to what AI can already do at the leading edge — not how much any particular employer has adopted. Adoption lags capability by years and lags unevenly: large, well-funded organisations first; small, rural, public-sector and thin-margin employers much later. The lag is a buffer, not a shelter. It buys time without changing direction.

We do not measure demand. A task can be highly automatable and highly in demand simultaneously. Where the labor market and our framework disagree, we say so in the profile rather than adjusting the score to fit.

We do not measure oversupply. The number of people entering a field is outside our six factors, and for some careers it matters more than automation.

We do not measure industry economics. A profession can contract for reasons entirely unrelated to technology.

We do not measure whether the work is worth doing. Pay, satisfaction, debt, hours and meaning sit outside the score and are covered separately in each profile — often at greater length, because for several careers they matter more.

Sub-track definitions are ours. Job titles vary between employers and countries. We have chosen tracks that reflect genuinely different work, not official classifications.

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7. What would change our mind

Each edition names specific, checkable indicators. If these move, the scores move — including downward.

Across the index:

- **Graduate hiring share.** If employers in the professions where we rate entry-path erosion highly return to hiring juniors at pre-2023 rates, those ratings fall.
- **Content of mandated training hours.** Several professions protect their on-ramp through required supervised experience. If the content of those hours shifts from producing work to supervising it, the protection weakens without any rule changing.
- **Offsite and prefabricated construction share.** The clearest test of our physical-protection ratings: automation performs well in controlled settings, so moving work indoors raises exposure without any robotics breakthrough.
- **Verified deployment rather than capability.** If adoption stalls materially below capability for several editions, our leading-indicator approach is overstating near-term risk and we will say so.

We will report movement in either direction. A framework that only ever revises upward is not measuring anything.

Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology.